

DSAT Reading & Writing — Main Idea

25 Original Practice Questions | Easy · Medium · Hard

Q1.

[Easy]

The following text is adapted from Lena Okafor's 2019 novel *Season of Dust*. Amara is visiting her grandmother's village for the first time in years. The road narrowed as they drove farther from the highway, and the houses grew smaller, their roofs weighted with the rust of decades. When Amara finally stepped out of the car, she recognized nothing—not the marketplace, not the stone well, not even the mango tree she had once climbed every afternoon. She had expected the village to greet her like an old friend, but it stood distant and unfamiliar, as though her memories belonged to someone else entirely.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Amara regrets having left her grandmother's village as a child.
 - B) Amara is surprised by how much the village has physically deteriorated.
 - C) Amara realizes that her grandmother has been concealing changes to the village.
 - D) Amara finds that the village no longer matches the memories she held of it.
-

Q2.

[Easy]

Tardigrades, microscopic animals sometimes called water bears, are renowned for their ability to survive extreme conditions. They can endure temperatures near absolute zero, withstand intense radiation, and tolerate the vacuum of outer space. Scientists have discovered that tardigrades achieve this resilience by entering a state called cryptobiosis, in which metabolic activity drops to nearly undetectable levels. In this state, the organism essentially suspends all biological processes until conditions improve.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Tardigrades are the only organisms known to survive in outer space.
 - B) Scientists recently discovered that tardigrades exist on every continent.
 - C) The metabolic processes of tardigrades are fundamentally different from those of all other animals.
 - D) Tardigrades survive harsh environments by entering a state of near-total metabolic suspension.
-

Q3.

[Easy]

A 2022 survey of over 3,000 remote workers found that 68 percent preferred a hybrid schedule—splitting time between home and office—over fully remote or fully in-person arrangements. Respondents cited social interaction with colleagues as the primary reason for wanting some office time, while flexibility and reduced commuting were the main advantages of working from home.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Remote work has been shown to decrease employee productivity compared with in-office work.
 - B) Most remote workers surveyed favored a hybrid work model, valuing both social interaction and flexibility.
 - C) Employers are increasingly requiring workers to return to the office full-time.
 - D) The survey revealed that commuting is the single greatest source of dissatisfaction among workers.
-

Q4.

[Easy]

The Rosetta Stone, discovered in 1799, bears the same decree inscribed in three scripts: hieroglyphic, Demotic, and ancient Greek. Because scholars could already read Greek, they used the Greek portion as a key to decipher the other two scripts. The stone thus became the essential tool that unlocked the ancient Egyptian writing system.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The Rosetta Stone was the most significant archaeological discovery of the eighteenth century.
 - B) The Rosetta Stone enabled scholars to decode Egyptian scripts by providing a readable Greek translation.
 - C) Ancient Greek was the most widely spoken language in the Mediterranean world.
 - D) The Demotic script was more complex than the hieroglyphic script on the Rosetta Stone.
-

Q5.

[Easy]

Coral reefs support roughly one quarter of all marine species, yet they cover less than one percent of the ocean floor. This extraordinary concentration of biodiversity has earned them the nickname 'rainforests of the sea.' However, rising ocean temperatures threaten coral health by causing bleaching, a process in which stressed corals expel the symbiotic algae that provide them with food and color.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Algae are responsible for the vivid colors found in tropical marine environments.
 - B) Marine biologists have recently discovered new coral species in deep ocean waters.
 - C) Coral reefs are biodiversity hotspots whose health is increasingly threatened by rising temperatures.
 - D) Coral reefs cover a larger percentage of the ocean floor than most scientists previously believed.
-

Q6.

[Easy]

The following text is from Tomoko Hara's 2016 short story 'Paper Boats.' Kenji folded the newspaper into a small boat and set it on the stream. He watched it drift toward the stone bridge, wobbling over the current, until it rounded a bend and vanished. Every day he did this, and every day he imagined it reaching the sea. He knew, of course, that it would disintegrate long before then, but the ritual gave him something he could not name—a quiet permission to hope.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Kenji's daily ritual of launching paper boats provides him with a sense of hope despite its futility.
 - B) Kenji is frustrated that his paper boats never reach the ocean.
 - C) Kenji builds boats because he dreams of becoming a sailor.
 - D) Kenji's neighbors find his daily habit strange and impractical.
-

Q7.

[Easy]

Psychologist Lev Vygotsky introduced the concept of the 'zone of proximal development,' which describes the gap between what a learner can accomplish independently and what the learner can achieve with guidance from a more skilled person. Effective teaching, Vygotsky argued, operates within this zone—neither too easy to bore the student nor too difficult to discourage effort.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Vygotsky believed that students learn best without adult intervention.
 - B) Vygotsky argued that gifted students do not benefit from traditional classroom instruction.
 - C) Vygotsky's theory holds that effective instruction targets the range just beyond a learner's independent ability.
 - D) Vygotsky conducted experiments proving that peer tutoring is superior to teacher-led instruction.
-

Q8.

[Medium]

Lichen, a symbiotic partnership between fungi and photosynthetic organisms such as algae or cyanobacteria, can colonize some of Earth's most inhospitable surfaces, including bare rock. The photosynthetic partner supplies sugars through photosynthesis, while the fungal partner provides structural support and protection from desiccation. Recent genomic studies have complicated this picture by revealing that many lichens also harbor yeasts and bacteria that contribute to the organism's chemical defenses, suggesting that lichen biology is more complex than the traditional two-partner model implies.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Lichen are able to grow on bare rock solely because of the structural support provided by their fungal component.
 - B) Scientists have determined that yeasts are more important to lichen survival than algae.
 - C) The fungi in lichen rely exclusively on algae for nutrition and cannot survive independently.
 - D) New research indicates that lichen partnerships involve more organisms than previously understood.
-

Q9.

[Medium]

During the early twentieth century, the Great Migration saw roughly six million African Americans relocate from the rural South to cities in the North, Midwest, and West. While economic opportunity was a primary motivator, historians emphasize that migrants were also fleeing the daily humiliations and dangers of Jim Crow segregation. The movement profoundly reshaped American culture: northern cities became centers of African American artistic and intellectual life, giving rise to movements such as the Harlem Renaissance.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The Great Migration was driven by both economic and social factors and had a lasting cultural impact on the United States.
 - B) The Harlem Renaissance was the most important cultural achievement of the twentieth century.
 - C) African Americans who participated in the Great Migration universally found better economic conditions in northern cities.
 - D) Jim Crow laws were the sole reason African Americans left the South during the early 1900s.
-

Q10.

[Medium]

The following text is from Raul Mendes's 2021 novel *Undertow*. Sofia kept returning to the half-finished painting in her studio, adding a brushstroke here, scraping away a layer there, never satisfied. Her professor had praised the composition, and two classmates had offered to buy it, but she could not see what they saw. To her the canvas revealed only what was missing—the shade of blue she could imagine but not mix, the texture that existed in her mind but refused to obey her hand.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Sofia's professor and classmates fail to appreciate the artistic vision behind her painting.
 - B) Sofia is determined to sell her painting despite her own dissatisfaction with it.
 - C) Sofia struggles with the gap between the ideal work she envisions and the reality of what she can produce.
 - D) Sofia lacks the technical training needed to complete the painting her professor assigned.
-

Q11.

[Medium]

Cephalopods such as octopuses and cuttlefish can alter the color and texture of their skin within milliseconds, a feat accomplished through specialized cells called chromatophores. Each chromatophore contains a sac of pigment controlled by tiny muscles; when the muscles contract, the sac expands and the color becomes visible. Beneath the chromatophores lie iridophores, which reflect light to produce iridescent hues. Working together, these cell layers give cephalopods one of the most sophisticated camouflage systems in the animal kingdom.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Chromatophores are found in all marine animals that can change color.
 - B) Cephalopods achieve rapid, sophisticated camouflage through layers of specialized skin cells that manipulate pigment and light.
 - C) Octopuses use camouflage primarily to attract mates rather than to avoid predators.
 - D) Scientists are unable to explain how cephalopod chromatophores respond so quickly to environmental stimuli.
-

Q12.

[Medium]

Behavioral economist Priya Nakamura has argued that default options—the choices that take effect when individuals do not actively make a decision—exert a disproportionate influence on outcomes. In a study of retirement savings, employees enrolled in plans with automatic contribution defaults saved, on average, 40 percent more than employees who were required to opt in manually. Nakamura contends that such findings challenge the classical economic assumption that individuals always make rational, utility-maximizing choices.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Retirement savings plans that use automatic enrollment are universally preferred by employees over opt-in plans.
 - B) Classical economic theory has been entirely discredited by recent studies in behavioral economics.
 - C) Employees who save more for retirement tend to earn higher salaries than those who save less.
 - D) Nakamura's research demonstrates that default settings significantly shape behavior, undermining assumptions about purely rational decision-making.
-

Q13.

[Medium]

In 1893, New Zealand became the first self-governing country to grant women the right to vote in national elections, a milestone achieved largely through the efforts of suffragist Kate Sheppard. Sheppard organized a series of petitions that collectively garnered nearly 32,000 signatures—representing roughly one quarter of the adult female population at the time. While New Zealand's achievement inspired suffrage movements worldwide, women in the country did not gain the right to stand for parliament until 1919.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Kate Sheppard single-handedly convinced New Zealand's parliament to grant women the vote.
 - B) New Zealand's suffrage movement was less effective than similar movements in Europe and North America.
 - C) New Zealand pioneered women's voting rights through organized activism, though full political participation for women came later.
 - D) The petition campaigns organized by Kate Sheppard were widely opposed by New Zealand's male population.
-

Q14.

[Medium]

Mycelial networks—underground webs of fungal threads—connect the root systems of trees in a forest, enabling nutrient exchange between individuals. Ecologist Jun Tanaka and colleagues found that seedlings growing in the shade of established trees received up to 30 percent of their carbon through these fungal connections. However, Tanaka cautions that the transfer is not purely altruistic: the fungi retain a significant portion of the nutrients as payment for their role as intermediaries.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Fungal networks facilitate nutrient sharing among trees, though the fungi themselves benefit from the exchange.
 - B) Seedlings cannot survive in shaded forest environments without fungal assistance.
 - C) Jun Tanaka has proven that trees intentionally share resources with weaker neighbors.
 - D) The fungi in mycelial networks are parasites that harm the trees they connect.
-

Q15.

[Medium]

The following text is from Delia Caron's 2018 poem 'Winter Kitchen.' My mother's hands moved like small, certain animals across the flour-dusted counter, folding air into dough as though she were folding the morning itself into bread. I learned her recipes by standing close enough to feel the heat of the oven on my face, and years later, when I open the flour tin, it is her kitchen I step into, not my own.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The speaker regrets not having formally documented the mother's recipes.
 - B) The act of baking evokes the speaker's powerful sensory memories of the mother's kitchen.
 - C) The speaker finds baking to be a tedious household chore despite the mother's enthusiasm for it.
 - D) The speaker's mother was a professional baker who ran a small neighborhood bakery.
-

Q16.

[Medium]

Urban planner Marcos Espinoza has observed that public parks in low-income neighborhoods frequently receive less maintenance funding than parks in wealthier areas, resulting in crumbling infrastructure and reduced foot traffic. This decline creates a feedback loop: as parks deteriorate, residents use them less, which in turn makes it harder for community advocates to argue for increased funding. Espinoza calls for equitable per-capita allocation of park maintenance budgets to break this cycle.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Low-income neighborhoods lack public parks entirely, which contributes to health disparities.
 - B) Marcos Espinoza has discovered that residents of wealthy neighborhoods use public parks more frequently than other residents do.
 - C) Public parks have no measurable effect on the quality of life in urban neighborhoods.
 - D) Unequal maintenance funding creates a self-reinforcing decline in parks serving lower-income communities, and Espinoza proposes equitable allocation as a remedy.
-

Q17.

[Medium]

When glass shatters, the resulting fragments follow surprisingly consistent patterns. Physicist Nadia Volkov demonstrated that the number of fragments produced is proportional to the energy of the impact, and that radial cracks always form before circumferential ones. These predictable fracture mechanics have forensic applications: by analyzing crack patterns, investigators can determine the point and force of impact even when the original object has been removed from the scene.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Nadia Volkov invented a new method for manufacturing shatter-resistant glass.
 - B) Circumferential cracks in glass are more useful than radial cracks for forensic investigations.
 - C) The study of glass fracture is a new field with no practical applications outside of physics.
 - D) Glass fracture patterns follow predictable rules that can be applied in forensic analysis.
-

Q18.

[Hard]

The prevailing model of planet formation holds that rocky planets like Earth accrete from collisions among progressively larger bodies called planetesimals. Astrophysicist Yara El-Amin has challenged this model by demonstrating that certain isotopic ratios in meteorites are inconsistent with the gradual accretion hypothesis. El-Amin proposes instead that some terrestrial planets may have formed through the rapid gravitational collapse of dense regions within the protoplanetary disk—a mechanism previously associated only with gas giant formation. While the hypothesis remains contentious, it has prompted renewed scrutiny of long-accepted assumptions about the early solar system.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) El-Amin has proven conclusively that rocky planets form through gravitational collapse rather than accretion.
 - B) A researcher's challenge to the standard model of rocky planet formation has sparked debate, though her alternative hypothesis has not been fully accepted.
 - C) Meteorite analysis has revealed that the solar system is significantly older than scientists previously estimated.
 - D) The mechanisms responsible for gas giant formation are now understood to be identical to those that produce rocky planets.
-

Q19.

[Hard]

Sociologist Elaine Whitfield has critiqued the widespread use of standardized achievement tests as measures of school quality. Whitfield argues that such tests primarily capture variance in students' socioeconomic backgrounds rather than differences in instructional effectiveness. She points to longitudinal data showing that schools serving affluent populations consistently outscore schools in lower-income areas even when the latter employ pedagogical methods rated highly by independent evaluators. Whitfield does not reject assessment entirely; rather, she advocates for value-added models that measure student growth over time, thereby isolating the school's contribution from pre-existing demographic advantages.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Whitfield has determined that affluent schools employ superior teaching methods compared with schools serving lower-income students.
 - B) Whitfield believes that all forms of student assessment should be eliminated because they are inherently biased.
 - C) Whitfield argues that standardized tests reflect socioeconomic factors more than school quality and recommends growth-based assessment models as an alternative.
 - D) Whitfield's research demonstrates that independent evaluators are unreliable judges of pedagogical quality.
-

Q20.

[Hard]

The following text is from Anwar Haddad's 2020 novel *The Cartographer's Silence*. He drew maps not of places he had been but of places he feared would vanish—marshes that the development authority had marked for draining, forests whose timber had already been auctioned. Each map was an act of preservation, a record of a landscape that might soon exist only on paper. His colleagues called the work sentimental, but he suspected that sentiment was merely the word people used when they wished to dismiss what they lacked the courage to feel.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The cartographer maps endangered landscapes as a form of preservation, viewing his colleagues' dismissal of his work as a failure of empathy.
 - B) The cartographer is motivated primarily by a desire to gain professional recognition from skeptical colleagues.
 - C) The cartographer's maps are inaccurate because they depict places he has never visited.
 - D) The development authority has hired the cartographer to document areas slated for commercial use.
-

Q21.

[Hard]

Deep-sea hydrothermal vents host ecosystems that rely on chemosynthesis rather than photosynthesis, deriving energy from chemical reactions involving hydrogen sulfide and other compounds. Marine biologist Adaeze Nwankwo has found that microbial communities at these vents exhibit metabolic flexibility, switching between sulfur oxidation and hydrogen oxidation depending on fluid chemistry. Nwankwo suggests that this adaptability may explain why vent ecosystems recover more rapidly than expected after volcanic disturbances that alter the chemical composition of the vent fluids.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Hydrothermal vent microbes rely exclusively on sulfur oxidation and are therefore vulnerable to changes in fluid chemistry.
 - B) The metabolic flexibility of vent microbes, documented by Nwankwo, may account for the resilience of vent ecosystems following volcanic disruptions.
 - C) Nwankwo has discovered that photosynthesis plays a larger role in deep-sea ecosystems than previously recognized.
 - D) Hydrothermal vents are the only deep-sea environments where chemosynthetic organisms can be found.
-

Q22.

[Hard]

Historian Camille Dubois has re-examined the conventional narrative that the printing press single-handedly democratized knowledge in fifteenth-century Europe. Dubois notes that early printed books were expensive luxury items, largely accessible only to ecclesiastical institutions and wealthy patrons. She argues that the true democratization of print occurred incrementally over two centuries, driven less by the technology itself than by declining paper costs, rising literacy rates, and the emergence of commercial lending libraries. The press, in Dubois's account, was a necessary but insufficient condition for widespread access to information.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Dubois has discovered that the printing press was invented earlier than historians previously believed.
 - B) Dubois contends that the printing press had a negligible impact on European society.
 - C) Dubois argues that the printing press alone did not democratize knowledge; broader social and economic changes over centuries were equally essential.
 - D) Dubois's research focuses primarily on the role of lending libraries in sixteenth-century France.
-

Q23.

[Hard]

Linguistic anthropologist Mei-Ling Zhou studies code-switching—the practice of alternating between two or more languages within a single conversation. While earlier scholars characterized code-switching as a sign of linguistic deficiency, Zhou's fieldwork among bilingual communities in Southeast Asia reveals that speakers deploy code-switches strategically to signal group identity, mark changes in topic, or convey shades of meaning unavailable in either language alone. Zhou concludes that code-switching is not a breakdown of linguistic competence but rather an expression of it.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Zhou's research demonstrates that code-switching is a deliberate, skilled communicative strategy rather than a sign of linguistic deficiency.
 - B) Zhou has proven that bilingual speakers in Southeast Asia prefer one language over the other in most social settings.
 - C) Earlier scholars correctly identified code-switching as evidence that bilingual speakers have not fully mastered either language.
 - D) Zhou's fieldwork focuses on documenting endangered languages in Southeast Asia before they disappear.
-

Q24.

[Hard]

Epigenetic modifications—chemical changes to DNA that affect gene expression without altering the underlying sequence—were long thought to be erased completely between generations. Geneticist Samuel Osei has presented evidence challenging this view: in experiments with laboratory mice, offspring whose parents were exposed to specific environmental stressors displayed altered stress-hormone levels even though the offspring themselves were raised in neutral conditions. Osei acknowledges that extrapolating these findings to humans requires caution, since the controlled conditions of laboratory research cannot replicate the complexity of human environments.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) Osei's research suggests that some epigenetic changes may be inherited across generations, though he urges caution about applying animal findings to humans.
 - B) Osei has conclusively proven that stress experienced by human parents is transmitted genetically to their children.
 - C) Epigenetic modifications permanently alter the DNA sequence and are therefore always inherited.
 - D) Laboratory experiments on mice have no relevance to the study of human genetics.
-

Q25.

[Hard]

The following text is from Ingrid Solheim's 2017 novel *Northern Meridian*. The lighthouse keeper recorded the weather not because anyone asked her to—the station had been automated years ago—but because the ritual of observation steadied her. Wind speed, cloud type, barometric pressure: each measurement was a sentence in a language that did not require interpretation. People's words, by contrast, always seemed to carry a second meaning she could not parse. The logbook, at least, said exactly what it meant.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A) The lighthouse keeper continues recording weather data because the precision of measurement offers her a certainty she cannot find in human communication.
 - B) The lighthouse keeper resents the automation of her station and refuses to abandon her post.
 - C) The lighthouse keeper is conducting unauthorized scientific research on coastal weather patterns.
 - D) The lighthouse keeper uses her logbook to communicate secretly with passing ships.
-